

7 Beatitude and the Beatitudes in Aquinas's *Summa Theologiae* (1998)

The Sources, Composition, and Situation of the Treatise on Beatitude

The opening questions of the *prima secundae* of St. Thomas's *Summa theologiae* are remarkable, considering the sources and materials they bring together, the care taken in their lengthy elaboration, and the place they occupy in St. Thomas's grand theological synthesis. The sources of these five questions on beatitude are clearly indicated, being quoted therein.¹ Of the theological sources, Scripture is cited sixty times and the commentaries of the Church Fathers receive sixty-one citations (forty-two citations from Augustine, eleven citations from Dionysius the Areopagite, and three citations from Ambrose and Gregory the Great). Of the philosophical sources, Aristotle is cited sixty-six times, Boethius is cited thirteen times, and there are two references to the *Liber de Causis*.

One can argue that St. Thomas's citations are more significant than those in modern works. In conformity with the *lectio* (i.e., the first stage of the Scholastic method, the "reading" of works known for their intellectual caliber), these citations indicate "authorities" in the order of erudition, all of which are accepted sources of enlightenment and knowledge. Aquinas's treatment of beatitude brings together authoritative texts of the Christian tradition

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1. [Editors' note: The editors have chosen to translate "*bonheur*" as "beatitude" rather than "happiness," both to remind the reader of Aquinas's particular understanding of the end or goal of human life, and to avoid the senses of "happiness" which are more psychic and transient than what Aquinas understood by "*beatitudo*."]

and philosophical traditions, especially the Aristotelian tradition. Furthermore, St. Thomas's citations are sometimes merely the tip of the iceberg, referring as they sometimes do to lengthy studies such as Boethius's *Consolation of Philosophy*, the reading of which is practically a necessity to understand the depths and nuances of Thomas's treatment of beatitude.

As for Thomas's treatments of the subject of beatitude, he worked on them all his life. He made three principal redactions. The first one is found at the end of his *Commentary on the Sentences*.² The second and third are in the *Summa contra Gentiles* and the *Summa theologiae*.

In addition, Thomas treats the subject of beatitude in several other places. His *Commentary on Aristotle's Nicomachean Ethics* was probably done in preparation for the *secunda pars* of the *Summa theologiae*.³ It clarifies first the definition of beatitude (Book I), then the nature of beatitude as an operation of the highest virtue in the order of speculative wisdom (Book X). The unfinished second book of the *Compendium theologiae* (1272) connects the question of beatitude with the virtue of hope, which is expressed in the Our Father, just as faith is expressed in the Creed.⁴ Here we have a sketch of our treatise. Finally, *Sermon 12, for the Feast of All Saints* (which is in the process of being published in the Leonine edition),⁵ contains a summary of our treatise in connection with the Gospel Beatitudes.

It is well to note especially the central and fundamental place given to the

2. [Editor's note: For St. Thomas's treatment of beatitude in his commentary on the *Sentences* of Peter Lombard, see "Aquinas's Pursuit of Beatitude: From the *Commentary on the Sentences* to the *Summa Theologiae*," essay #6 in *The Pinckaers Reader*.]

3. [Editor's note: An English translation is St. Thomas Aquinas, *Commentary on Aristotle's Nicomachean Ethics*, trans. C. I. Litzinger, O.P. (Notre Dame, Ind.: Dumb Ox Books, 1993). Torrell argues that this commentary was composed in Paris in 1271–72, and that it was contemporaneous with the composition of the *secunda secundae* of the *Summa theologiae*, for which it was a preparation. Torrell also notes the existence of a "tabula" or index of the principal themes of the *Nicomachean Ethics*, an unfinished work composed in 1270, when Thomas was preparing to write the *secunda pars*.]

4. [Editor's note: An English translation is St. Thomas Aquinas, *Compendium of Theology*, trans. Cyril Vollert, S.J. (St. Louis: B. Herder, 1947).]

5. [Editor's note: Here Pinckaers is referring to St. Thomas's sermon *Homo quidam fecit cenam magnam*, established as one of nineteen authentic sermons in Aquinas's *Opera Omnia* by L.-J. Bataillon in "Les sermons attribués à saint Thomas: questions d'authenticité," *MM* 19 (1988): 325–41. Pinckaers translates this sermon in "Un sermon inédit de saint Thomas," *Sources* 12 (1986): 9–22.]

questions on beatitude in the *Summa*. Freed from the constraints of Peter Lombard's plan, Thomas shifts the treatise on beatitude from the last place to the first, in conformity with Aristotle's *Nicomachean Ethics*, the thought of St. Augustine, and the method of the Lord himself (in the Sermon on the Mount). Placed at the pivotal juncture between the *prima pars* and the *secunda pars*, these questions are not merely a simple preamble to the moral section of the work, but form a veritable keystone which supports the whole. Beatitude, seen as the last end, will furnish higher criteria governing the principal treatises: the treatise on human acts;⁶ the virtues, especially the theological virtues;⁷ sin, chiefly mortal sin;⁸ law;⁹ and the grace of the Spirit in the New Law.¹⁰

This threefold consideration shows us the importance and interest of the treatise on beatitude. It is the centerpiece in the construction of the *Summa theologiae*, to such an extent that the *secunda pars* may accurately be described as the morality of beatitude.

In view of this, we cannot help regretting that the treatise on beatitude has enjoyed so little success, even in the Thomist tradition, and that it was definitely excluded from fundamental moral theology by the authors of the manuals. For example, Juan Azor, the Spanish Jesuit who at the beginning of the seventeenth century offered the earliest example of the method of the manuals, while claiming that he followed St. Thomas's order, never in fact mentions the treatise on beatitude, and begins his elucidation of fundamental morality with human acts. Post-Tridentine moralists were capable of setting forth an entire exposition of moral theology, as did St. Alphonsus in his voluminous *Moral Theology*, without seeing any need to speak of beatitude. In fact, the mention of beatitude was actually suspect, as if it implied a self-interested, egotistical desire. The result was a veritable divorce between morality and beatitude, something which still obtains—the implication being that a person must sacrifice beatitude in order to be faithful to the moral law. The same crucial problem also turns up in philosophy with the Kantian critique of eudaemonism in the name of the categorical imperative and of a duty-oriented morality.¹¹

6. *ST* I-II 6, prologue.

7. *ST* I-II 62.1.

8. *ST* I-II 72.5.

9. *ST* I-II 90.2.

10. *ST* I-II 107.1; 108.3.

11. [Editor's note: For a lengthier narration of this historical development, see Pinckaers, *Sources of Christian Ethics* (Washington, D.C.: The Catholic University of America Press, 1995).]

In order to demonstrate the current significance of the problem of the relationship between beatitude and morality, let us now examine the structure of St. Thomas's treatise on beatitude.

The Question of True Beatitude

St. Thomas was not in the habit of leaving his readers with unanswered questions, nor of guiding them along roads which led nowhere. After having acknowledged, in the prologue to the second part, that God created humans in His image, conferring on them mastery of their actions through free will, St. Thomas at once takes up the question which God had inscribed in the human heart, a spontaneous, natural, and universal question. As St. Augustine wrote, in a text of the *De Trinitate* cited by St. Thomas: "If the comedian [who promised to tell the audience what each person wanted] had said, 'You all want to be happy, you do not want to be wretched,' no one at all would fail to recognize this desire at the root of their will. Whatever else a man might want in the secret depths of his heart he never forgets this desire, which is well known to all, and is in all."¹²

Philosophers, and people in general, have given many different and contradictory answers to this natural question. The decisive question would therefore be: what is man's true beatitude? Thomas responds by making a joint appeal to the wisdom of the philosophers, who are the interpreters of human experience, and to the teaching of the Gospel, commented upon by the Fathers of the Church who are the authorized interpreters of the Christian experience. Drawing upon these rich traditions, Thomas constructs a path, one which is built as solidly as a Roman road. It will lead to the twin affirmations that God alone can fulfill the human longing for beatitude, and that ultimate beatitude can lie only in the vision of the Divine essence, according to the Divine promise: "When he appears we shall be like him, for we shall see him as he is."¹³

Thus, in the light of the Gospel, and with the help of philosophy, Thomas traces for us, beginning with the desire of beatitude, a path which rises toward God, a path comparable to the ways of demonstrating the existence of God.

12. Augustine, *De Trin.*, Book XIII, ch. 3; cited in *ST I-II* 5.8.

13. 1 Jn 3:2 (RSV); cited in *ST I-II* 3.8.

This description takes up, principally, the first three questions, and evokes the image of a highway. At the center, a long white line extends indicating the direction; this is the first question, on finality. On either side of the line lie the two aspects of the problem. To the right is the objective side: in what good does human beatitude consist?¹⁴ On the left is the subjective side: from a human point of view, what actions will make a person blessed?¹⁵ The remaining two questions bring out, first, the subjective elements of beatitude¹⁶ and then the powers and means a person uses to attain to the promised beatitude.¹⁷

Beatitude is both objective and subjective. It is objective, because it is caused by a good reality, one which renders person good and blessed. It is subjective, because it corresponds to the desire of man, which carries him toward the good and beatitude. The avowal of a lover, “*You are my beatitude*,” well expresses this constitutive duality. On the one hand, it is formed by the person who is the object of love. On the other hand, it is the sentiment of beatitude which the person who is the object of love causes in the lover. Let me add that for Thomas, as for Augustine, the term *bonum* combines inseparably the ideas of the good and of beatitude: what is good is what makes one blessed; what is evil is what makes one wretched. One of the tragedies of modern ethics lies in the separation imposed between the good, conceived of a pure obedience to law (something which renders ethics tedious), and beatitude, which is suspected of egoism.

The Way of Beatitude

Let me briefly outline the path to beatitude, according to St. Thomas.

The Finality of Acts

At the center there runs the line of finality. Like a spinal column it controls the structure of morality. Thanks to a person’s reason, it is proper to her to act in view of an end,¹⁸ which specifies the quality of her acts,¹⁹ and joins them to an ultimate finality which orders her whole life, as well as all her acts.²⁰ This ultimate end transcends individual action, and works as the chief unifying

14. *ST I-II* 2.

16. *ST I-II* 4.

18. *ST I-II* 1.1–2.

20. *ST I-II* 1.4–6.

15. *ST I-II* 3.

17. *ST I-II* 5.

19. *ST I-II* 1.3.

principle with regard to all person, through the societies which they form.²¹ The ultimate end even creates an active solidarity between human persons and all other creatures.²² Thus we rise from the finality that informs our particular acts to an ultimate finality which rejoins the Divine finality operating in the government of the universe, and particularly in human beings.²³

I should like to note two points here. Firstly, we are dealing with a kind of continuous finality, in contrast to the more brief and occasional finality of casuistry, which is limited to individual actions and cases of conscience, and forms not a line but a series of disconnected dots without any order. On the one hand, then, we have a fundamental finality in morality, and on the other a subjective finality which has become a component of the action itself.

Secondly, we need to avoid confusing the finality which Thomas is considering with the modern, technical finality which has become increasingly commonplace with the development of the natural and social sciences. In the *Summa* we are dealing, not with a technical finality related to some external work, mechanically realizable according to its relation to intermediate ends, but with a moral finality which unfolds within a human being and bears on his or her personal acts, such as desire and love, as well as on intention, deliberation, and choice, which are the sources of human action. The great difference between these two finalities consists in the fact that personal acts may have as their object human qualities and persons lovable in themselves, that is, as ends. Examples of these personal acts (e.g., charity, truth, or friendship), however, are ordered by us and for us in virtue of one single and ultimate end, thereby granting us access to this end, and are not given as mere means or instruments to be discarded after their use. In this way, Christ himself, as Thomas says, “has shown us in his own person the path of truth which, in rising again, we can follow to the blessedness of eternal life.”²⁴ It is by loving Christ as a person, and not merely as a means to beatitude, that Christ becomes for us a path to our ultimate end, namely blessedness in God. It is at the heart of our personal experience that we discover this finality.

Since Thomas had no knowledge of technical finality in the modern sense, he did not make all the clarifications which are now necessary in a discussion of this subject. However, Thomas does bring out the finality inscribed in the

21. *ST* I-II 1.7.

23. *ST* I 103.

22. *ST* I-II 1.8.

24. *ST* III prologue.

nature of various realities, such as riches, power, virtue, and, indeed, in the human person. It is not, therefore, a question of a finality fabricated by human beings, or of a technology. It is this singling out of a natural finality that gives to Thomas's reflections a solidity which guarantees their permanent worth.

The Objective Aspect of Beatitude

Returning to our analogy of the highway: the right side of the path of beatitude is more concrete, in conformity with the itinerary toward God mapped out by St. Augustine in his contemplation at Ostia,²⁵ by Aristotle in his *Nicomachean Ethics*, and by Boethius in his *Consolation of Philosophy*. Its form is negative: the ultimate end and complete beatitude of the human person does not consist in riches (whether natural or monetary), nor in honors, nor in reputation and glory in the eyes of others, nor in the possession of power. It is easy to see the timeliness of these issues for our society, dominated as it is by political and economic questions. The search then deepens, penetrating into human nature itself: the ultimate end cannot reside in the goods of the body, such as health (valuable though this is), nor in pleasures, nor in goods of the soul such as knowledge and virtue, nor in any other created good, but in God alone, who, according to Psalm 102, "satisfies you with good as long as you live." This path directs the natural desire toward the good and toward beatitude. The ordering to God alone as sovereign Good therefore constitutes both the ultimate end and the supreme criterion of human acts, both at the personal and at the social level.

Note that this account, while it describes an intellectual search, indicates at the same time (though perhaps a little too subtly) a spiritual journey beginning with ascetical detachment from external goods, continuing with detachment from interior goods, and culminating in a summit which could be called mystical, namely a union with God lived above all else as the Unique One, as the Ultimate End, and as Perfect Blessedness. We are reminded of Teresa of Avila's words, "God alone suffices." God is indeed the universal Good, the source of all good. This lengthy undertaking begins in the human heart with its faculty of loving and desiring, and is rounded off by an indication of the positive contribution of goods, even of corporeal ones and of those external to us, to the search, carried on in this world, for beatitude in God.²⁶

25. Augustine, *Conf.* IX.10.23–26.

26. *ST* I-II 4.

The Subjective Aspect of Beatitude

The second path, on the left side of the road to beatitude, is concerned with the action of the person who is following it, and principally in the intellect, which grasps the good and presents it to the will. Here, likewise, progress is made through negation: complete beatitude cannot be the work of sense perception,²⁷ but rather of our spiritual faculties, and primarily of our intellect.²⁸ It is not, however, the work of the practical intellect but of the speculative intellect, which seizes upon truth and goodness in themselves as the perfection of contemplation.²⁹ This knowledge cannot be limited to the speculative sciences such as the various branches of philosophy;³⁰ it must even surpass the knowledge of angelic intellects which are superior to ours,³¹ in order to open itself out mysteriously to the measure of the vision of the Divine essence.³²

Here, then, is a new aspect of Christian asceticism: that intellectual and spiritual detachment produced by the desire for truth, which urges us firstly to transcend sensible perceptions, then to transcend the ideas formed by our reason, then finally to transcend the intuitions of our mind, in order to allow the development within us of that contemplation, at once obscure and luminous, intelligent and unknowing, which is proper to faith in this life.

When we reflect on these texts of the *Summa* we can read between the lines to discern the spiritual experience of the Angelic Doctor, an experience animated by the ardent love of truth which spurred Thomas on to seek God before all other realities, as his biographer William of Tocco tells us. We are not in his case dealing with a purely intellectual search, one which might become so abstract in its series of transcendent moves that it might risk vanishing like a rocket into the space of concepts, and even beyond that. From beginning to end, Thomas's venture remains linked with the desire for beatitude and that love of goodness which moves the will. In his very succinct and sober style he describes for us the progress of our spiritual appetite, which unites the desire for truth with the love of the good, thus directing all the movements of the human mind and heart toward God. The pathway built by Thomas is in-

27. *ST* I-II 3.3.

29. *ST* I-II 3.5.

31. *ST* I-II 3.7.

28. *ST* I-II 3.4.

30. *ST* I-II 3.6.

32. *ST* I-II 3.8.

deed predominantly intellectual and sapiential, just like the teaching of the Fathers of the Church; but it is at the same time unitive through the love of God, which is strengthened by charity and the desire for beatitude, and lifted higher by the virtue of hope.

We can therefore compare our treatise on beatitude with the works of those spiritual writers and mystics who describe the stages of the human person's ascent to God. In his rigorous and sparse language, Thomas describes the theological structure of that search for God which is capable of touching the human heart: without God there is no perfect beatitude for the human person, nor any adequate response to his or her deepest longing for truth and goodness. For Thomas, God is the very source, the object and the cause of true beatitude. As Augustine said, "You have made us for yourself O Lord, and our hearts are restless until they rest in you."³³

Two Difficulties

However powerful and rich these texts which St. Thomas devotes to beatitude may be, they still leave the reader with two questions:

1. Why is it that in the *Summa* Thomas cites the Gospel Beatitudes only once (the Beatitude of the pure of heart in connection with the rectitude required in the will: *ST* I-II 4.4), whereas in his *Commentary on St. Matthew* he presents the Christ of the Beatitudes as the sage *par excellence*, who gives the perfect answer to the question of true beatitude of which philosophers could never adequately treat? Is he standing aloof from the Beatitudes in this regard?

2. Furthermore, when he treats of the incomplete nature of the beatitude which is attainable in this life, St. Thomas always refers, in our questions, to Aristotle, without ever including Christian insights drawn from the Gospel or from patristic teaching concerning, for example, the usefulness of bodily health,³⁴ of external goods,³⁵ of the contributions of friends,³⁶ or, again, of the attainment or loss of beatitude in this life.³⁷ We get the impression that he systematically avoids all mention of the Beatitudes in the treatise on beatitude, and omits the contributions of the Gospel and of Christian experience from his description of the beatitude attainable in this life.

33. Augustine, *Conf.* I.1.1.

35. *ST* I-II 4.7.

37. *ST* I-II 5.3-4.

34. *ST* I-II 4.6.

36. *ST* I-II 4.8.

The Explanation of the Beatitudes, the Culmination of the Treatise on Beatitude

The *lacunae* we have just mentioned find their explanation, I believe, in the structural demands of a rigorously systematized work like the *Summa theologiae*. The treatise on beatitude is not finished; it awaits a completion foreseen in the overall plan of the work. This completion is the question in the *prima secundae* devoted to the evangelical Beatitudes.³⁸ There we are given a detailed description of the Christian beatitude which can already be experienced in this life, as a preparation for, and a prefiguring of, future blessedness.

The separation between the treatise on beatitude and the question on the evangelical Beatitudes is explicable on historical and methodological grounds. These studies created different problematics in theology in the thirteenth century. In his *Commentary on the Sentences*, St. Thomas studies the Beatitudes after the gifts of the Holy Spirit.³⁹ The question is: how are the Beatitudes to be distinguished from the virtues and gifts, with which they are connected by St. Augustine? This was the problem debated by the “Masters.” Thomas, therefore, would not deal with the Beatitudes in the treatise on beatitude placed at the end of his *Commentary* on the fourth book, but rather discussed the Beatitudes in conjunction with the virtues and gifts which underpinned his entire moral construction. In the *Summa* the order is reversed and the study on beatitude comes first. It is followed by the Beatitudes, which are grafted on to the analysis of the virtues and gifts; but the distance separating them in the plan is such that the connection is lost on many readers.

This historical reason overlays a more systematic one which is of particular interest to us. St. Thomas refuses to define the Beatitudes as *habitus*, and presents them instead as perfect acts. They designate the work of the virtues, and more especially of those gifts which enable us to act more perfectly through the grace of the Spirit. In this way Thomas puts into our hands all the elements needed to describe Christian beatitude in this life. Beatitude issues from the exercise of the virtues animated by charity, the “heart of perfection,” under the inspiration of the gifts which cause us to act with excellence and render us more docile to the Holy Spirit. Thus, through the virtues and gifts

38. *ST I-II* 69.

39. *III Sent.*, dist. 34.

the most finished spiritual work is achieved, the fulfillment of the Beatitudes. It is like a fruit which has come to full maturity.

The relation of the Beatitudes to the virtues and gifts is so important in St. Thomas's view that he introduces it into the structure of the *secunda secundae*. To each virtue he relates a gift, and in the question discussing it he indicates the Beatitude which corresponds to this gift. We are dealing, therefore, with a morality of beatitude which begins to be realized in this life in the practice of the Beatitudes, through the work of the virtues and gifts.

The Description of Christian Beatitude in This Life in the Light of the Beatitudes

An attentive reading of the four articles devoted to the Beatitudes in the *Summa* shows that St. Thomas considered his question on the Beatitudes to be very important.⁴⁰ In it he described what for him is the perfection of the Christian life, the summit of Gospel spirituality. These few pages are so full and so richly delineated that they remind us of a vast tapestry, worked out down to the finest lace-like detail. Thomas takes consummate care in his explanation of the Beatitudes, because he saw in them both the response of the Lord himself to the question of beatitude, and a precise description of the paths leading to the promised blessedness. With St. Augustine, he held that the Beatitudes are inchoate in this life and are a preparation for future beatitude, or even an imperfect but real beginning of blessedness, as can be seen in the lives of the saints.⁴¹

I should like to point out here that St. Thomas did not know, and would certainly have rejected, the modern distinction between morality and spirituality, or between asceticism and mysticism, which has removed the gifts and the Beatitudes from moral theology. For him the moral life, ordered to the perfection of charity with the help of the virtues, attains its fullness in the action of the Holy Spirit working through the gifts, and reaches its summit through the practice of the Beatitudes. As the organization of the *secunda pars* shows, the gifts and the Beatitudes, as well as the virtues and precepts, are not reserved for a chosen few but concern all Christians. With the Beatitudes we reach that

40. *ST* I-II 69.

41. *ST* I-II 69.2.

level in the moral life which is rendered accessible through the grace of the Spirit.

The Sources for Thomas's Treatment of the Question on the Evangelical Beatitudes

I should like to show in a few words the importance of the question on the Beatitudes from the consideration of its sources.⁴² Let us take the theological sources first. Obviously, St. Matthew's statement of the Beatitudes at the beginning of the Sermon on the Mount is most important. Concerning this, St. Thomas notes that all the Beatitudes contained in Scripture should be referred to this key text.⁴³ Now the Sermon on the Mount is the specific text of the New Law, which is defined as the grace of the Holy Spirit received through faith in Christ.⁴⁴ The realization of the Beatitudes in the Christian life should therefore be accomplished through faith in the Christ who spoke them, and with the help of the Spirit from whom flows all the energy of this interior law. In this light, the Christological and spiritual character of St. Thomas's moral theology becomes evident.

To demonstrate more precisely how the action of the Spirit works, our Doctor takes up and interprets in his own way the tradition created by St. Augustine in his preaching on the Sermon on the Mount, where Augustine had the idea of relating the Beatitudes to the gifts of the Spirit enumerated in Isaiah 11. For Augustine, the Beatitudes describe the Christian journey from conversion in humility to purity of heart and the attainment of peace in God. According to the teaching of St. Paul, however, the Christian cannot follow this path without the help of the Holy Spirit. This intervention of the Spirit manifests itself in the correspondence between the seven Beatitudes and the seven gifts which St. Thomas takes up in all his works, basing it on the relationship to the seven principal virtues. In this way he organizes to the best advantage the moral heritage both of the Gospel and of the Fathers of the Church.

Nevertheless, in order to explain the Beatitudes, St. Thomas does not hesitate to make use of philosophical categories borrowed from Aristotle, notably the distinction between the three kinds of life corresponding to the three types

42. *ST I-II* 69.

43. *ST I-II* 69.3 ad.4.

44. *ST I-II* 106.1.

of response to the question of beatitude: the life of pleasure, which is rejected by the first three Beatitudes; the active life, with which the fourth Beatitude on justice and the fifth on mercy both deal; and finally, the contemplative life, related to the Beatitudes of the pure of heart who shall see God, and the peace-makers.⁴⁵ This distinction shows that the Beatitudes are concerned with human life in its entirety, and characterize it according to the kind of beatitude which is sought. These categories can also be applied to societies.

The division of the human faculties likewise contributes to the interpretation of the Beatitudes, as does the distinction between the irascible passions, regulated by the Beatitudes of the meek, and the concupiscible passions, the concern of the Beatitudes of those who mourn. This shows the human rootedness of the teaching.

As with the treatise on beatitude, the question on the Beatitudes combines the riches of the traditions of the Gospel, the Fathers of the Church, and the philosophers, but with a definite emphasis on the Gospel.

A Brief Look at the Question on the Beatitudes

Obviously we cannot engage in an in-depth study of this question here.⁴⁶ I shall simply give a general outline, to whet your appetite. St. Thomas begins by distinguishing the Beatitudes from the virtues and the gifts, while showing their coordination. We can move toward beatitude through the acts of the virtues and gifts: these acts are the Beatitudes.⁴⁷ The analysis of the Beatitudes which follows is based on the relationship, fundamental in moral theology, between merit and reward—it being understood that merit proceeds essentially from charity and the Holy Spirit. The rewards promised in the Beatitudes come to us already in this life, as both a beginning of blessedness and a preparation for it.⁴⁸ The detailed explanation of the Beatitudes describes the actions which they either disparage or recommend, ordered according to the distinction of the three kinds of life: the life of pleasure, the active life, and the contemplative life, depending on the kind of beatitude which is sought. It shows the different ways in which the Beatitudes may be accomplished, whether according to the rational measure of virtue or according to the inspiration of the

45. *ST* I-II 69.3.

47. *ST* I-II 69.1.

46. *ST* I-II 69.

48. *ST* I-II 69.2.

gifts.⁴⁹ Finally, Thomas explains the rewards of the Beatitudes by showing how each one fulfills, on a higher plane, those desires which urge humans toward false or imperfect forms of beatitude. Thus, for example, when the poor realize the spiritual riches to be found in God, this discovery sublimates their desire for earthly goods.

We might say that St. Thomas really wanted to include his entire moral teaching in this question on the Beatitudes, in order to show that it reaches its summit in the fulfillment of the Beatitudes, so as to place everything under the aegis of the Word of the Lord, which he considers to be the Teacher par excellence.⁵⁰

The Beatitudes, Fruits of the Virtues and Gifts

In closing, I should like to draw your attention to the comparison St. Thomas makes, in the accomplishment of the Beatitudes, between what virtue commands in accordance with the measure of reason, and what the gifts inspire in accordance with the higher measure of the Holy Spirit. Through the first Beatitude virtue teaches us to use external goods in moderation, according to our need of them, but the gift of the Spirit goes further and would have us scorn material goods entirely, so as to detach our heart from them without reserve. Such was the evangelical poverty actually practiced by St. Dominic and St. Francis. As the second Beatitude, virtue moves us to control the irascible appetites (anger and fear) with due reason. The gift of the Spirit keeps the soul tranquil in the face of even the greatest danger, as happened in the case of the martyrs. Regarding the concupiscible appetites with which the third Beatitude deals, virtue would lead us to use these movements of sensibility with due measure, while the gift detaches us from them altogether, giving us a spirit of compunction and penance in union with the Passion of the Lord, according to the monastic tradition. Likewise, the Spirit causes us to “give each one his due” in justice, with a fervent desire which is like hunger and thirst, in the way that St. Louis, the contemporary of Aquinas, administered justice in the kingdom of France. It also moves us to practice mercy by giving generously to all in need, beyond the bounds of friendship or kinship, as did so many saints, such as St. Vincent de Paul.

49. *ST* I-II 69.3.

50. *ST* III 7.7.

These brief indications of St. Thomas concerning the practice of the Beatitudes could be extended by reference to his study of the particular virtues and gifts. They show clearly the nature of the beatitude which the Christian can have in this life. Its source is within the person, in the place where virtue is formed in the light of reason illumined by the Word of Christ, and where the Holy Spirit is at work in its depths, inspiring the most personal and noble acts.

Finally, in order to recount all the riches of life lived according to the Spirit, St. Thomas thought it appropriate to add to the Beatitudes the fruits of the Holy Spirit as enumerated by St. Paul in his Letter to the Galatians:⁵¹ charity first, as the prime source of beatitude; then joy, which serves to define beatitude as “joy in the truth”; and peace, which renders it perfect.⁵² Is not “fruit” the best image of beatitude—a fruit that has acquired its full perfection and beauty? It is the image of a life’s work which has reached its maturity.

We can say that St. Thomas’s teaching on beatitude and the Beatitudes is one of the most beautiful fruits of his theological genius, nourished by the Gospel and the reflections of the Fathers of the Church. Is it not a cause for regret that for four centuries, and even still in our own day, the treatise on beatitude and the questions on the gifts and Beatitudes have been omitted from the handbooks of moral theology? Surely we should extol the *Catechism* for having reintroduced them into the teaching of fundamental moral theology.⁵³ Let us hope that the Holy Spirit will lead moralists to grasp the importance of this innovation, which bears within it a principle of the renewal and rejuvenation of moral theology.

This is the path to beatitude proposed by the moral and spiritual teaching of St. Thomas, a central path directing our entire life to God as to our blessedness. It is built on solid foundations: Christian experience, founded on the Rock of the Word of Christ (as the patristics testified) and human experience, interpreted and witnessed to by the most lucid of the philosophers. This, it seems to me, is the best and most enlightening gift, the most joyful message that St. Thomas could give to us today.

51. Gal 5:22–23.

52. *ST* I-II 70.

53. *CCC*, 1716–24; 1830–32.